

VELA — The Universal Conlang

A minimalist auxiliary language built on English roots

The VELA Project

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Preface

VELA is a **constructed auxiliary language** (an *auxlang*): a language designed on purpose to be learned quickly and spoken by people from any linguistic background as a shared second tongue.

It is built on one uncompromising promise:

You read it exactly as you write it, and you write it exactly as you say it.

There are no silent letters, no irregular verbs, no grammatical gender, no cases you must memorize, and no sound a beginner cannot produce. A Spanish speaker, an English speaker, and a Japanese speaker read the same word *make* the same way — *MA-ka* — and mean the same thing: *make*.

This book is the **reference manual** — the *what* and the *why* of VELA. It describes the sound system, the grammar, the way words are built, how the ~2,900-word lexicon was constructed, and the design decisions behind every choice. It is not a course; if you want to *learn* to speak VELA, read the companion volume, *Learning VELA — Level 1*.

Everything in this book was ratified by a review committee of three linguistic specialists — a **morphologist**, a **phonologist**, and a **semanticist** — who reviewed the language batch by batch. Where a decision was contested, this book records the reasoning, not just the outcome.

Part I — Why VELA

1.1 The problem VELA solves

Natural languages are wonderful and terrible teachers. English has *through*, *though*, *tough*, and *thought* — four spellings, four pronunciations, no rule. It has *go* / *went*, *good* / *better*, *mouse* / *mice*. A learner spends years memorizing exceptions before they can hold a conversation.

Existing auxiliary languages fixed *some* of this. Esperanto (1887) is beautifully regular but leans heavily on European roots and keeps grammatical case endings and accusative markers. Toki Pona (2001) is gorgeously tiny (~120 words) but so minimal that it cannot express precise meaning without long paraphrase.

VELA aims for the middle: **regular like Esperanto, but simpler; expressive like a natural language, but without the exceptions.**

1.2 The four principles

Every decision in VELA is measured against four principles, in strict priority order. When two principles conflict, the earlier one wins.

1. **Simplicity** — the smallest set of rules that still works. Zero irregular verbs. Zero grammatical gender. One plural rule. One way to form the past tense.
2. **Transparency** — a speaker should be able to *decompose* what they hear. sik-hous is *sick-house* (hospital). no-nof-po is *not-know-person* (stranger). Meaning is visible in the parts. The ending -po means “*the person who does X*”, and it is perfectly regular: hunt-po is a *hunter*, wud-mak-po is a *wood-make-person* — a **carpenter**, lern-po is a *teacher*. Learn one ending, and a whole family of words opens up. That regularity is the whole point.
3. **Beauty** — the language should be pleasant to hear and to read. Open syllables, a gentle pitch accent, and sound-symbolic roots give VELA its character.
4. **Universality** — a person from *any* language background should be able to pronounce and learn it. This is why VELA restricts its sounds to the ones found in the vast majority of the world’s languages, and why every word can end in a vowel.

1.3 Why English roots?

VELA takes most of its root vocabulary from English — not out of preference, but out of reach. English is today’s most widely studied second language; anchoring roots to English gives the largest number of learners a head start in *recognizing* words.

But VELA is **not English**. It strips English of everything that makes it hard: the chaotic spelling, the silent letters, the irregular grammar, the sounds many languages lack. What remains is a recognizable skeleton — mama, watre, gud, big, luk — respelled phonetically and regularized completely.

A note on recognizability vs. pronunciation. The English word *make* “looks right” to an English speaker — but only because they read it with the English pronunciation /meɪk/, which VELA cannot use (silent *e*, diphthong, hard final *k*). In VELA that word is maka /'ma.ka/: two open syllables any speaker on Earth can produce. Recognizability is a means, not the master; universality wins.

1.4 What VELA borrows — four worlds, four strengths

VELA is not built from nothing. It deliberately takes the single best idea from each of four traditions and leaves the rest behind:

Source	What VELA takes
English	its recognisable, globally-studied root vocabulary — the head start of familiar words
Japanese	its transparent word-compounding — building new meaning by joining small roots (<i>far-tok-box</i> = <i>far-talk-box</i> = telephone), the way Japanese builds words from smaller parts
Esperanto	its complete grammatical regularity — one rule, no exceptions, no irregular verbs
Phonetic science	a minimal, universal sound system — only the vowels and consonants shared by the vast majority of the world's languages

The **Japanese principle** is the heart of VELA. Instead of memorising thousands of unrelated words, you learn a compact set of roots and *combine* them. If you know *sik* (sick) and *hous* (house), you already know *sik-hous* (hospital); if you know *wud* (wood), *mak* (make) and *-po* (person-who), you already know *wud-mak-po* (carpenter). Meaning is built, not memorised — exactly as a Japanese speaker reads a two-*kanji* compound and sees its parts.

Part II — Sounds and Spelling

VELA's spelling *is* its pronunciation. Learn the sound of each letter once, and you can pronounce every word in the language forever.

2.1 The consonants (20)

Letter	IPA	As in English	VELA example
p	/p/	p it	pikni (picnic)
t	/t/	t alk	taiṃ (time)
k	/k/	c ar, k ite	kar (car)
b	/b/	b all	beḷ (bell)
d	/d/	d og	dog (dog)
g	/g/	g o	gud (good)
m	/m/	m an	man (man)
n	/n/	n ice	nais (nice)
f	/f/	f ish	faiṛ (fire)
v	/v/	v an	visa (visa)
s	/s/	s un	son (sun)
z	/z/	z oo	zon (zone)
sh	/ʃ/	sh ip	shaiṇ (shine)
h	/h/	h ouse	houṣ (house)
l	/l/	l ove	luva (love)
r	/r/	rolled r (Spanish)	rich (rich)
w	/w/	w ater	watṛe (water)
y	/j/	y es	yelo (yellow)
ch	/tʃ/	ch ild	chua (chew)
j	/dʒ/	j oy	jaṛa (jar)

The two affricates **ch** /tʃ/ and **j** /dʒ/ were admitted by unanimous committee vote in 2026: about 74 core words already needed them (teach, child, chuz, oranja), removing them would have caused fatal collisions (*chip* → *ship*, *jen* → *zen*), and they are among the most common consonants worldwide.

Deliberately absent: English *th* /θ ð/ (as in *think*, *this*) and *zh* /ʒ/ (as in *measure*). These sounds are rare across the world’s languages and hard for many learners; VELA has no use for them.

2.2 The vowels (5)

VELA uses the five “pure” vowels shared by Spanish, Japanese, Italian, Swahili, and hundreds of other languages:

Letter	IPA	As in
a	/a/	Spanish <i>casa</i>
e	/e/	Spanish <i>mesa</i> / English <i>bet</i>
i	/i/	English <i>see</i>
o	/o/	Spanish <i>solo</i>
u	/u/	English <i>food</i>

There is **no vowel length**, **no nasal vowels**, and every vowel is always pronounced the same way. The letter never lies.

2.3 The syllable rule: (C)V

Every VELA syllable is **one optional consonant plus one vowel**: *ma*, *ki*, *lo*, *a*. This “open syllable” structure is the single most universal shape in human language — it is the easiest for the largest number of people to say.

From this one rule follows everything about how VELA sounds: *ma.ma*, *wa.tre*, *si.ti*, *ba.na.na*. You can clap out any word.

Tolerated endings. A word may end in a vowel *or* in one of the soft “sonorant” codas {**n**, **m**, **l**, **r**, **s**} (and *-ng*): *man*, *sistem*, *gud*... wait — *gud* ends in /d/. That is a *legacy* form (see §2.5). New words and citation forms always end in a vowel or a soft coda.

2.4 Where the accent falls — one rule for every word

VELA does not use heavy, unpredictable stress like English (*PHO-to-graph* → *pho-TO-gra-phy*, where the beat jumps around and you simply have to know it). Instead it uses a light, **fully predictable pitch accent**:

The rule: the voice rises gently on the **second-to-last (penultimate) syllable** of the word. Always. No exceptions.

Count the syllables, step back one from the end, and lift the pitch there:

Syllables	Word	Accent	Say it
1	si (see)	the only one	si
1	go (go)	the only one	go
2	ma.kā (make)	1st	MA ·kā
2	si.ti (city)	1st	SI ·ti
3	fa.mi.li (family)	2nd	fa· MI ·li
3	ba.na.na (banana)	2nd	ba· NA ·na
4	im.por.ten.ta (important)	3rd	im·por· TEN ·ta

One-syllable words (si, go, man, la) simply carry the pitch on their single syllable — there is nowhere else for it to go.

How the dictionary shows it. In a pronunciation like / 'ma . ka/, the little mark ' sits right before the stressed syllable: / 'ma . ka/ = **MA**·ka, /fa . 'mi . li/ = fa·**MI**·li. Dots separate the syllables.

Compounds are read as one long word: count every syllable and accent the second-to-last of the whole thing. far·tok·box (telephone) → far·**TOK**·boks; each root also keeps a light beat of its own, but the main lift is still on the penultimate.

Because the rule never changes, you never memorize where the accent goes — and unlike English (*RE-cord* the noun vs. *re-CORD* the verb), **misplacing the accent in VELA never changes a word's meaning**. At worst you sound a little foreign; you are always understood.

2.5 Legacy sounds and “write-as-you-speak”

VELA's earliest vocabulary predates the strict (C)V rule, so a handful of very common words still end in hard consonants: gud (good), big (big), at, of, and. These are **grandfathered** — kept as-is because they are short, hyper-frequent, and tolerated by most languages as small function words.

Everything else obeys **write-as-you-speak**: what you see is what you say, with no silent letters and no surprises.

Part III — How Words Are Built

This is the heart of VELA. Instead of thousands of unrelated words, VELA builds meaning from a compact set of roots joined by transparent, productive patterns.

3.1 Roots and the citation/composition rule (R7)

A **root** is a minimal unit of meaning: mak (make), luk (look), tok (talk).

Because VELA wants every word to be pronounceable *alone*, a content root with a hard final consonant takes two shapes:

- **Citation form** (the dictionary entry, used when the word stands alone): root + a → maka, luka, toka, aska, teacha.

- **Composition form** (used inside compounds): the **bare** root → mak-tin (make-thing = product), luk-for (look-for = seek), tok-tin (talk-thing = topic).

The learner's rule is one line: *inside a compound, drop the -a.*

This citation/composition alternation is not an oddity — it is a well-attested feature of natural languages: Spanish epenthesis (*estado*), Latin *rex / reg-*, Japanese *jin / nin* (人), Turkish *ev / ev-e*. It lets VELA keep both easy standalone pronunciation *and* short, economical compounds.

3.2 Compounding

VELA joins roots with a **hyphen**, and the hyphen carries meaning — it marks exactly where one root ends and the next begins, so a compound is always decomposable:

- sik-hous = *sick + house* = **hospital**
- no-nof-po = *not + know + person* = **stranger**
- watre-fal = *water + fall* = **waterfall**
- star-fish = *star + fish* = **starfish**

A compound may hold at most **three roots**. The hyphen is what keeps VELA transparent: without it, *sikhous* could be read as one opaque word; with it, *sik-hous* is self-explaining.

3.3 The productive series

Over ~2,900 words, a handful of patterns became fully productive “machines” for generating vocabulary. Learn these and you can build — and understand — thousands of words you have never seen.

-mak — the causative (*make X*): from an adjective, build the verb “to make it so.”

Adjective	Verb (-mak)	Meaning
strong	strong-mak	to strengthen
wik (weak)	wik-mak	to weaken
hard	hard-mak	to harden
soft	soft-mak	to soften
big	big-mak	to enlarge

-wei — manner and direction (*the X way*): from a quality, build an adverb.

Root	Compound	Meaning
soft	soft-wei	gently
slo	slo-wei	slowly
fronta (front)	fronta-wei	forward
bak	bak-wei	backward

-nes — abstract nouns (*the quality of being X*):

Root	Compound	Meaning
strong	strong-nes	strength
wik	wik-nes	weakness
gud	gud-nes	goodness
tru (true)	tru-nes	truth

-po — people and roles (*person who does X*):

Compound	Meaning
wud-mak-po	carpenter (wood-make-person)
sik-kea-po	nurse (sick-care-person)
god-serv-po	priest (god-serve-person)
hunt-po	hunter

-tok — speech acts (*a way of talking*):

Compound	Meaning
swita-tok	to flatter (sweet-talk)
angri-tok	to scold (angry-talk)
bak-tok	to gossip (back-talk)
lo-tok	to mutter (low-talk)

no- — negation and reversal:

Compound	Meaning
no-biju	ugly (not-beautiful)
no-real	fake (not-real)
no-tai	to untie
no-loka	to unlock

Reduplication — intensity: repeating a root intensifies it.

Compound	Meaning
big-big	vast
smol-smol	tiny
slo-slo	gradual
tru-tru	indeed / truly

3.4 The loan policy

When no transparent compound is natural — for atomic concepts like *tomato*, *guitar*, or *asthma* — VELA borrows the international word and adapts it to a legal form ending in **-a**: *tomata*, *gitara*, *astama*. Across the lexicon, about 85% of loans already end in **-a**, giving the language one consistent vocalic rhythm.

Part IV — Grammar

VELA’s grammar is deliberately tiny. This entire part can be learned in an afternoon.

4.1 Word order — SVO

VELA is **Subject–Verb–Object**, always.

Mi luk la kat. — *I see the cat.* (I / see / the / cat)

The object always follows the verb. Word order does the work that case endings do in other languages, so almost nothing needs a suffix.

4.2 Articles

- **la** — the (definite): *la person* = *the person*
- **un** — a/an (indefinite): *un person* = *a person*
- **no article** — general/plural sense: *pipol* = *people in general*

Note: *person* is the neutral word for *a person* (any gender); *pipol* is *people*. *man* means specifically *an adult male* and *wuman* *an adult female* — VELA never uses the word for “male” to mean “person”.

4.3 Pronouns

VELA	Meaning
mi	I / me
yu	you
li	he / she / it
wi	we
de	they

There is **no grammatical gender**: li covers *he, she, and it* alike, and de covers *they* for any group.

“One word for he, she, and it — isn’t that confusing?” It is one of the most widespread patterns in the world’s languages, not an oddity. Spoken **Mandarin Chinese** uses a single third-person pronoun tā for *he, she* and *it* — the written distinction (他 / 她) is a 20th-century borrowing from European languages, and roughly a billion speakers manage without it every day. **Turkish** (o), **Persian** (u), **Indonesian** (dia), **Tagalog** (siya), **Finnish** (hän) and **Hungarian** (ő) do the same. In practice there is no confusion: you name the person first (*Ana kom. Li es hapi.* — Ana comes. She is happy.), and context does the rest — exactly as Spanish routinely drops the subject entirely. VELA makes li genderless **on purpose**: it is simpler to learn, and it never forces a speaker to assign a gender to anyone.

Possession uses **-se** (see §4.5) or the short possessive mi-se (my), yu-se (your), etc.

4.4 Nouns, plural, and case

Plural adds **-n** after a vowel, **-en** after a consonant:

- kat → kat-en (cats)
- siti → siti-n (cities)

Cases — VELA has only two suffixes, because word order handles the rest:

Case	Marker	Example	Meaning
Nominative (subject)	— none —	person	the person (does)
Accusative (object)	— none —	person	the person (is acted on)
Genitive (of/’s)	-se	person-se	the person’s / of the person
Locative (at/in/on)	-to	siti-to	in the city

La person-se hous es big. — *The person's house is big.* **Mi liv la siti-to.** — *I live in the city.*

4.5 Adjectives

Adjectives come **before** the noun and never change form or take case:

un big hous — *a big house* **la gud person** — *the good person*

Right before a noun the adjective is bare, as above. Standing alone after **es**, it takes its full dictionary form: **La hous es biga.** — *The house is big.* (attributive big, predicative biga).

Comparison uses **mor** (more) and **mos** (most):

- big — big
- mor big — bigger
- mos big — biggest

4.6 Verbs — three tenses, zero irregulars

This is VELA's proudest simplicity. **Every** verb, without exception, forms its tenses the same way — two endings and an **unmarked present**:

Tense	Marker	Form	Example
Present	(none)	the dictionary word itself	maka (make / makes)
Past	-ed	bare root + -ed	mak-ed (made)
Future	-wil	bare root + -wil	mak-wil (will make)

The **present is simply the word as the dictionary lists it** — there is no present ending to add. Past and future attach to the short root (the same short form used inside compounds):

si (see) · si-ed (saw) · si-wil (will see) maka (make) · mak-ed (made) · mak-wil (will make)

The ending never depends on the subject: *mi* maka, *yu* maka, *li* maka, *wi* maka, *de* maka. There are **no irregular verbs and no spelling changes** — ever. (*Why no present -a? Because a content root's citation form already carries a helper vowel where the sound needs it — maka — so adding a present -a would clash with it. The dictionary form does double duty as the present.*)

The verb **“to be”** is the one exception: *bi* has the present form **es** (past **es-ed**, future **wil es**):

Mi es hapi. — *I am happy.* **La kat es big.** — *The cat is big.*

4.7 A worked example

La smol child-en play-ed in la garden, and de es hapi.

The small children played in the garden, and they are happy.

Breaking it down: la (the) · smol (small) · child-en (child + plural) · play-ed (play + past) · in (in) · la garden (the garden) · and (and) · de (they) · es (are) · hapi (happy). No irregular forms, no memorized exceptions.

Part V — The Lexicon

5.1 How VELA got its ~2,900 words

VELA's vocabulary was not invented in one sitting. It grew from ~1,300 to ~2,900 headwords through roughly thirty themed **batches** — nature, the body, emotions, verbs, science, food, clothing, tools, medicine, finance, law, travel, music, and more.

Each batch passed through a strict pipeline before entering the language:

1. **Author** ~100–160 candidate words for a domain, favoring transparent compounds and borrowing only for atomic concepts.
2. **Validate** every word against the phonotactic rules (the (C)V structure, legal codas, no forbidden sounds) with an automated checker.
3. **De-duplicate** twice — once by exact spelling, and once **by meaning** (comparing each new word's gloss against every existing gloss), so that a concept already covered under a different spelling is never added twice.
4. **Review** by the three-specialist committee, each judging from their angle: the morphologist checked structure and duplicates, the phonologist checked pronounceability and beauty, the semanticist checked transparency and loan justification.
5. **Integrate** the survivors, regenerate the dictionary, and commit.

Twelve of the final seventeen batches passed committee review with **zero changes** — a sign that, by the end, the patterns of the language had become predictable enough that new vocabulary practically wrote itself.

5.2 Loans vs. compounds

VELA prefers a transparent compound whenever one is natural (watre-fal for *waterfall*, no-hop-fel for *desperate*). It borrows an international word only for genuinely atomic concepts that resist compounding — species names (elefanta), instruments (gitara), sciences (kemistri), diseases (astama). Across the lexicon the loan/compound balance settled around 60% loans, 40% compounds — heavier on compounds in everyday domains, heavier on loans in technical ones.

5.3 Keeping it clean

Two invisible disciplines kept the lexicon from rotting:

- **Semantic de-duplication.** Early on, the same concept kept re-entering under different spellings (*flour* as both flaur and bred-pauda). A gloss-based check now blocks this before every batch.

- **Base normalization.** The oldest layer of the lexicon carried spelling duplicates (bel t/bela) and hard-to-pronounce forms. A committee-ratified cleanup removed ~120 redundant entries and gave every hard-coda content root its vowel-final citation form — while carefully *not* merging words that only looked like duplicates (cloud/crowd, computer/calculator).

Part VI — VELA in Use

6.1 Everyday phrases

English	VELA
Hello!	Helo!
Good morning.	Gud morne.
How are you?	Hau yu?
Thank you.	Tanke yu.
You're welcome.	Yu welkom.
Please.	Plise.
I'm sorry.	Mi es sori.
Yes / No	Ok / No
Goodbye.	Gudbai.

6.2 A short passage

La son shain-a over la mar. Un smol bird flai-a hai in la klar skai. It sing-a un hapi song, and la wind karri-a la sonj far.

The sun shines over the sea. A small bird flies high in the clear sky. It sings a happy song, and the wind carries the sound far.

6.3 How VELA compares

Feature	English	Esperanto	Toki Pona	VELA
Irregular verbs	many	none	none	none
Grammatical gender	none	none	none	none
Spelling = sound	no	yes	yes	yes
Grammatical cases	none	2	none	2 (both suffix-less in practice)
Core vocabulary	huge	large	~120	~2,900
Root source	Germanic	European	a-priori	English, phonetic

VELA sits deliberately between Esperanto’s expressiveness and Toki Pona’s minimalism: expressive enough for real communication, simple enough to learn in weeks.

Appendix A — Quick Grammar Reference

- **Word order:** Subject–Verb–Object.
- **Articles:** la (the), un (a).
- **Plural:** -n after vowel, -en after consonant.
- **Genitive:** -se. **Locative:** -to.
- **Adjective:** bare before the noun; full (citation) form when alone after es.
- **Comparison:** mor (more), mos (most).
- **Verb tenses:** present = the dictionary word, past -ed, future -wil. No irregulars.
- **“To be”:** bi (present es).
- **Negation:** no before the word.
- **Compound:** roots joined by -, max three, transparent.

Appendix B — The Sound Chart at a Glance

Consonants (20): p t k b d g m n f v s z sh h l r w y ch j **Vowels (5):** a e i o u **Syllable:** (C)V. **Accent:** pitch, on the second-to-last syllable. **Absent by design:** *th* /θ ð/, *zh* /ʒ/, vowel length, nasal vowels.

Appendix C — Productive patterns cheat-sheet

Pattern	Builds	Example
X-mak	verb “make X”	strong-mak = strengthen
X-wei	adverb “X-ly / X-ward”	soft-wei = gently
X-nes	abstract noun	tru-nes = truth
X-po	person/role	hunt-po = hunter
X-tok	speech act	bak-tok = gossip
no-X	negation/reversal	no-loka = unlock
X-X	intensification	big-big = vast
citation ↔ composition	maka alone, mak- in compounds	drop -a inside compounds

*VELA is an open language project. This reference describes the language as ratified in 2026 at ~2,900 words. To learn to speak it, continue with **Learning VELA — Level 1**.*